

The Locked Room

The apartment had only three rooms if you were being generous.

A kitchen that doubled as a dining room.
A living room that doubled as a bedroom.
And the locked room.

Aria Monroe stared at the peeling white door at the end of the hallway while balancing a tray of cold coffee mugs against her hip.

The lock had been there her entire life.

When she was seven, she'd asked her mother what was inside.
"Nothing important."

At twelve, she'd tried picking the lock with a bobby pin.
Her mother had caught her and grounded her for a month.

At twenty-seven, she knew better than to ask questions.
At least, that's what she told herself.

The floorboards creaked behind her.

"You're staring at it again."

Her younger brother, Noah, leaned against the wall with a grin.

"I'm not."

"You totally are."

Aria rolled her eyes and walked toward the kitchen.

"Don't you have homework?"

"No."

"Then find some."

He laughed.

The sound warmed something inside her.

Noah was sixteen now. Smart. Funny. The kind of kid who deserved a future bigger than this apartment and the overdue bills stacked on the counter.

The kind of future Aria worked double shifts to provide.

She dropped the mugs into the sink.

The clock read 11:48 p.m.

Another fourteen-hour day.
Another night calculating which bills could wait and which couldn't.

Her mother's cough echoed from the bedroom.

Aria immediately turned toward the sound.

The cough came again.
Worse this time.

Her chest tightened.

Hospital visits cost money.
Medicine cost money.
Everything cost money.

And somehow there was never enough.

By midnight, everyone else was asleep.

Aria sat alone at the kitchen table with a calculator and a notebook.

Numbers.
Always numbers.

The rent.
The electricity.
The pharmacy.

No matter how many times she rearranged them, they never changed.

She rubbed her eyes.

Something shifted down the hallway.

Click.

Aria froze.

The locked room.

For a moment she thought she'd imagined it.

Then she heard it again.
A metallic scrape.

Her pulse quickened.

Slowly, she stood.

The apartment was silent.
The hallway seemed darker than usual.

She approached the door.

One step.
Then another.

The old brass handle gleamed in the moonlight.

The lock wasn't fully engaged.

For the first time in her life, it looked slightly open.

Aria's breath caught.

A dozen memories flooded back.

The arguments her mother thought she hadn't heard.

The mysterious envelopes that sometimes appeared in the mailbox.

The expensive men in dark suits she'd occasionally noticed watching their building.

The way her mother always changed the subject whenever Aria asked about her father.

Her hand settled on the handle.

This was it.

Every answer she'd ever wanted sat on the other side.

Just one turn.

Just one look.

The cough came again from her mother's bedroom.

Weak.

Painful.

Human.

Aria closed her eyes.

Family first.

Always.

She stepped away from the door.

Whatever secrets waited inside could wait another night.

She returned to the kitchen, picked up her notebook, and started calculating bills again.

Behind her, unnoticed, the door eased open a fraction wider.

Inside the dark room sat a single metal box.

On top of it rested a file.

A photograph.

And a name.

Aria Monroe.

Beneath it, stamped in red ink:

RESERVED.

The door slowly clicked shut.

And Aria never heard it.

Not yet.